

Illusory Correlation

What is it?

People believe two things are related even when no real connection exists.

History

Recognized in psychology research since **1967**, when studies revealed people tend to form relationships between unrelated events simply because they appeared together. The mind prefers meaningful patterns over randomness.

The Psychology Behind It

- Brain tries to simplify the world by linking events
- Emotional triggers amplify false associations
- Confirmation bias strengthens the belief over time
- Timing and visuals can mislead perception

Why It Matters

- Incorrect product assumptions
- Wrong interpretations of features
- Misjudged brand perception
- Confusion during troubleshooting
- Emotional resistance to change

How to Apply It

- Use clear confirmations and feedback
- Visually separate unrelated actions
- Educate gently using tooltips, microcopy, and onboarding
- Avoid design changes that accidentally imply cause-and-effect

Theory in Action

- Adobe branding leads people to assume that using Adobe software directly makes them more creative
- Red Bull branding convinces people that the drink gives extreme energy and adventurous performance, even though that perception comes mostly from marketing cues

Final Thought

Users create stories in their mind whether you guide it or not.

Shaping the narrative intentionally prevents false patterns from becoming permanent beliefs.